



SME DATA UNLOCK

A SME SUSTAINABILITY REPORTING USE CASE

FURNA METALI DOO, *PODGORICA*

Montenegro



About The SME Data Unlock Alliance

SME Data Unlock Alliance is an open source initiative being coordinated in Norway to bridge the SME sustainability data divide in countries and regions across the globe. Public-private consortia will drive the development of AI-powered SME Data Unlock Data Exchange Platforms that give SMEs access to automated sustainability data that already exists in government repositories, regulatory authorities, and utility systems. With this data SMEs can meet reporting and procurement data requirements and unlock green finance. SME Data Unlock is a transformative global solution with a special focus on Emerging and Developing Economies (EMDEs) where SMEs often face the greatest data barriers.

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Introduction

Montenegro's small and medium-sized enterprise (SME) sector stands at a critical crossroads in the European supply chain. The country boasts over 63,800 active businesses, with micro-enterprises and SMEs forming the backbone of the private sector, comprising roughly 99%. From metal processors and energy subcontractors to agricultural cooperatives, food processors, and tourism providers, this vibrant ecosystem drives the national economy. However, these businesses are increasingly caught in a relentless regulatory data storm. This pressure is driven by policymakers in Brussels and Frankfurt, as well as by the corporate boardrooms of major EU companies that rely heavily on Montenegrin goods and services.

The Toll of EU Compliance

As Montenegro advances toward EU accession, its progress is closely tied to Chapter 27 (Environment and Climate Change). Simultaneously, the country must grapple with a wave of stringent European regulations, including:

- CSRD (Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive)
- CSDDD (Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive)
- CBAM (Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism)

Each of these frameworks reaches deep into Montenegrin supply chains. They compel local companies to deliver comprehensive, auditable environmental, social, and governance (ESG) data—a sophisticated requirement for which many are entirely unprepared.

The Reality on the Ground: A Tale of Scattered Data

To understand the friction this creates, consider Furna Metali DOO, a fictional but highly representative 28-employee metal fabrication firm in Podgorica.

The Bottleneck Isn't Capability—It's Connectivity. Furna Metali is not struggling with a lack of capacity. It is a well-managed, technically adept, and financially stable enterprise. The true obstacle lies in Montenegro's fragmented data infrastructure.

While the sustainability data required for EU compliance technically exists within national registries, utility systems, and environmental agencies, it remains isolated in silos. It is scattered, difficult to access, and designed for bureaucratic oversight rather than agile business operations.

Bridging this digital divide is no longer optional. Unlocking and streamlining this data infrastructure is essential to ensure that Montenegro's SMEs can weather the upcoming regulatory shift, protect their access to European markets, and continue to fuel the national economy.

Sustainability reporting is not a capacity problem. It is a data infrastructure problem.

About Furna Metali DOO

Mila Radović is the owner-director of Furna Metali DOO, a 28-person metal fabrication and structural steel processing company based in Podgorica's industrial zone. The company supplies precision-cut steel components and structural assemblies to three sectors: the construction and real estate market in the Budva-Kotor coastal zone, an Italian-backed industrial logistics company operating a regional warehouse facility near Nikšić, and — through a recently won sub-contract — an Austrian-headquartered energy infrastructure company involved in Montenegro's first renewable energy auction projects.

Furna Metali operates a fabrication hall, a CNC cutting workshop, a surface treatment area using chemical degreasers and zinc-based coatings, and a small vehicle fleet for local deliveries. Its environmental footprint includes electricity consumption from the national grid (which relies substantially on the Pljevlja coal-fired thermal power plant), industrial waste streams including metal offcuts, chemical solvents, and zinc-contaminated rinse water, and direct diesel emissions from its delivery vehicles. The company has operated for eleven years, employs a mix of skilled welders, machine operators, an HSE supervisor, and three administrative staff. By any normal measure, it is a competent and well-run Montenegrin SME

In April 2026, four separate sustainability data requests arrived within three weeks — from four different counterparties, using four different frameworks, with no overlapping definitions.

Four Requests in Three Weeks

The first demand: the Italian logistics company (CSRD Scope 3)

Furna Metali's longest-standing client, an Italian-headquartered logistics firm, is subject to CSRD reporting for the first time in fiscal year 2026. It must disclose Scope 3 Category 1 emissions — the embedded carbon in the goods and services it purchases. Its procurement team has issued a supplier data collection template to Montenegrin subcontractors. The template asks for: total Scope 1 and Scope 2 GHG emissions for calendar year 2025; the carbon intensity of steel products supplied, in kg CO_{2e} per tonne; evidence of the company's waste management practices with tonnage breakdowns by stream; and confirmation of compliance with Montenegro's Law on Accounting 2025, including whether Furna Metali falls within the non-financial reporting mandate. Failure to respond within 30 days risks removal from the approved supplier register.

The Second demand: the Austrian energy company (CSDDD due diligence)

The Austrian energy company — recently brought into scope under the CSDDD's chain-of-activities provisions — has retained a Vienna-based ESG consultancy to conduct supplier due diligence across its Western Balkan subcontractors. The questionnaire sent to Furna Metali runs to 22 pages.

About Furna Metali DOO

It asks for documentation of the company's human rights and labour practices, evidence of chemical discharge management under Montenegro's EPA permitting system, a description of the company's approach to managing zinc and solvent waste streams, and a quantified assessment of the company's exposure to climate transition risks — specifically, the risk that Montenegro's heavy reliance on coal-fired electricity will affect Furna Metali's competitiveness as CBAM is implemented.

The third demand: NLB Banka (green loan product)

Furna Metali has approached NLB Banka for a preferential credit facility to finance the replacement of its aging CNC cutting machine with a more energy-efficient model — a EUR 180,000 capital investment. NLB's green loan product, aligned with the EU Taxonomy and EBA ESG risk guidelines that entered into force in January 2026, requires: documented Scope 1 and Scope 2 emissions baselines; evidence of the company's existing electricity consumption profile; a forward-looking assessment of how the new equipment will reduce operational carbon intensity; and a physical climate risk assessment for the company's Podgorica facility, including flood risk exposure under a 10-year scenario. The loan officer apologetically explains that the bank's supervisory obligations make this documentation mandatory — not optional.

The fourth demand: the Montenegro EPA (ETS compliance)

Montenegro's Environmental Protection Agency has notified Furna Metali that its surface treatment operations, which involve zinc-based electroplating processes, may fall within the scope of the revised Climate Law's Monitoring, Reporting, and Verification provisions, depending on verified emissions levels. The EPA's letter requests a formal self-assessment of the company's direct and process emissions, referencing the national ETS registry. Mila is uncertain whether Furna Metali is actually in scope — the thresholds are defined around industrial installation capacity, and the company's surface treatment area operates below what she believes are the relevant limits — but she cannot obtain a clear regulatory interpretation without submitting the assessment.

None of the four requests uses the same definitions, reference periods, or data formats. Each is, in isolation, manageable. Collectively, they represent a systemic burden for a 28-person company with no dedicated sustainability function.



The Upstream Regulatory Stack

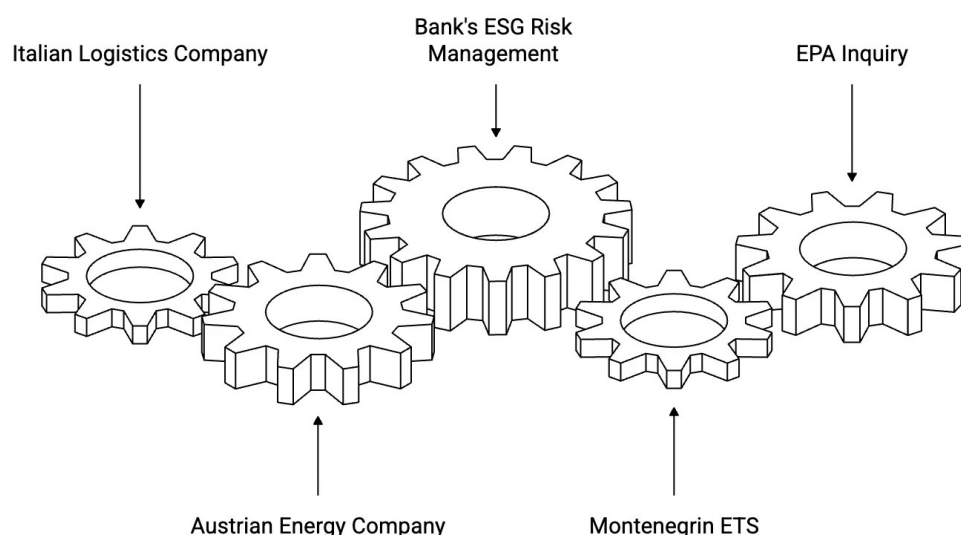
None of Furna Metali's counterparties is acting arbitrarily. Each is responding rationally to obligations embedded in a layered regulatory structure.

The Italian logistics company's Scope 3 requirements flow directly from the CSRD and its mandatory European Sustainability Reporting Standards (ESRS). As an in-scope company reporting for the first time under the post-Omnibus thresholds (1,000 employees and €450 million turnover, confirmed by Directive (EU) 2026/470), it must disclose material environmental impacts across its entire value chain — including Scope 3 Category 1 emissions from Montenegrin steel suppliers.

The Austrian energy company's due diligence request is grounded in the CSDDD, which requires large EU companies to conduct continuous due diligence across their 'chain of activities.' Montenegro's position as a candidate country does not exempt its businesses from this chain. The directive's civil liability provisions mean that the Austrian company faces direct legal risk if it cannot demonstrate that its Montenegrin subcontractors meet defined human rights and environmental standards.

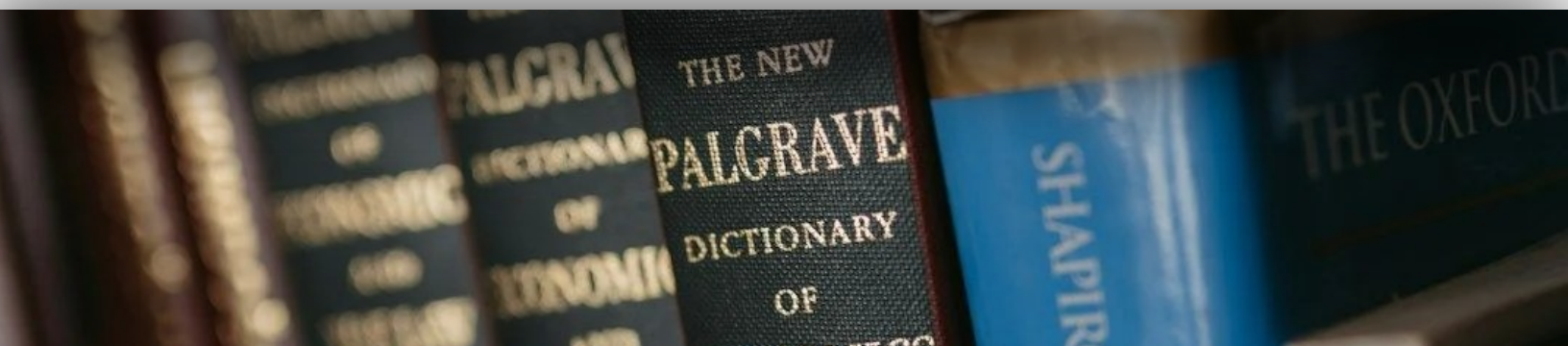
The bank's requirements reflect the EBA's ESG risk management guidelines, operative since January 2026. These guidelines require Montenegrin financial institutions — including NLB, which is subject to the Law on Credit Institutions — to systematically identify climate-related risks across their lending portfolios. Green loan products are, in practice, a mechanism for extracting assurable sustainability data from borrowers. NLB needs Furna Metali's emissions baseline not to obstruct the loan, but because its own supervisory compliance depends on it.

Montenegro's national ETS, established under the 2019 Climate Law and revised in December 2025 to align with EU MRV rules, creates direct domestic reporting obligations for certain industrial emitters. The EPA's inquiry reflects the agency's obligation to enforce these rules — obligations that have sharpened as Montenegro's EU accession negotiations accelerate through Chapter 27.



The Regulatory Stack Bearing Down on Furna Metali

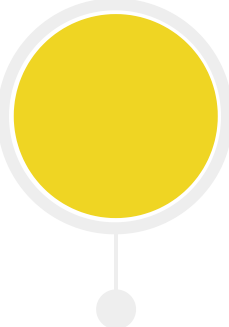
Regulatory Level	Instrument	Obligation for Furna Metali
EU Level	CSRD / ESRS	Supply chain Scope 3 data to EU buyers
EU Level	CSDDD	Human rights & environmental due diligence documentation
EU Level	CBAM	Embedded carbon risk in steel exports; transition cost exposure
EU Level	EBA ESG Guidelines (Jan 2026)	Emissions baselines required for green finance access
Montenegro National	Climate Law 2025 / ETS	MRV self-assessment; potential permit obligation
Montenegro National	Law on Accounting 2025	Non-financial reporting if classified as large entity
Operator / Client Level	Voluntary ESG frameworks (EFRAG VSME)	Energy intensity, GHG, waste data for investor-driven requests



What Mila Encounters

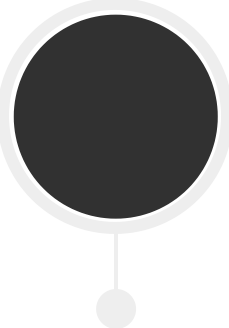
Mila passes the stack of documents to her Health, Safety, and Environment Supervisor, Dragan. He is experienced in occupational safety and familiar with Montenegro's occupational health regulations. He has never encountered the term 'Scope 2 market-based emissions factor' or been asked to quantify 'embedded carbon intensity per ton of steel product.'

He opens a spreadsheet and begins.



Electricity and grid emissions

Furna Metali's electricity is supplied by EPCG (Elektroprivreda Crne Gore). The invoices show kWh consumed and EUR billed. Dragan knows that Montenegro's grid relies substantially on Pljevlja's coal plant, but he also knows that the Piva hydropower facility and other renewable sources contribute significantly. The Italian questionnaire asks for a specific grid emissions factor for the calendar year 2025, expressed in gCO_{2e}/kWh. Montenegro's Regulatory Energy Agency (RAE) publishes average emissions intensity data, but it is not disaggregated by delivery point, not available in machine-readable form, and the most recent published figure Dragan can locate dates from 2023. He uses this figure, notes the uncertainty, and moves on.

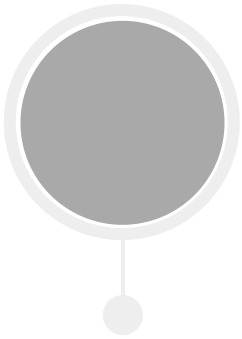


Zinc waste and chemical discharge data

Furna Metali's surface treatment operations generate zinc-contaminated rinse water and spent chemical solutions. These are collected by a licensed waste operator and transported to a treatment facility. The waste operator provides collection records — dates, approximate volumes in liters, and manifest codes. The CSDDD questionnaire asks for waste tonnage broken down by hazardous and non-hazardous streams, referencing Montenegro's EPA waste classification codes. Dragan contacts the waste operator, who explains that tonnage data is submitted to the EPA's environmental permitting system under their own operating license — but that data belongs to the operator, not Furna Metali, and the EPA does not make it accessible to the waste-generating company in a machine readable format. He estimates the weight using density conversions, flagging the approximation.

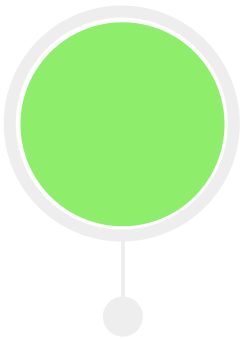


What Mila Encounters



Physical climate risk — flood and temperature

The Austrian questionnaire and the bank's green loan application both ask about physical climate risk at the Podgorica facility — specifically flood risk under a 10-year return period scenario, and temperature-related operational disruption risk. Montenegro's Institute of Hydrometeorology and Seismology maintains flood risk and climate projection data. The EPA maintains environmental permit zone information. Neither database is accessible through a structured API. Dragan navigates multiple government portals, finds a general flood risk map for the Podgorica region, and concludes that the facility is likely not in a high-risk zone — but he cannot produce a site-specific risk assessment in the format the questionnaire requires, nor can he cite a verifiable, time-stamped data source.



ETS scope determination

The EPA letter asks Furna Metali to self-assess whether its surface treatment operations exceed the thresholds that would bring it within the national ETS. The relevant threshold is defined in terms of 'rated thermal input' of industrial combustion installations. Furna Metali does not directly operate combustion equipment above the threshold — but its surface treatment heating system is borderline. Dragan cannot locate a clear official interpretation of how electroplating heating systems are classified. He drafts a response asserting the company is below the threshold, based on his best reading of the Climate Law's annexes, but has no certainty this interpretation is correct.

By the end of week one, Dragan has partially answered two of four requests. Most responses are approximations, referenced to inconsistent time periods, and — though he does not know this — incorrect in at least one instance where he applied an outdated emissions factor.

The Data Already Exists — It Is Just Not Where Furna Metali Needs It

Many of the figures Dragon struggled to compile already exist in Montenegrin public-sector databases and regulatory systems, in more accurate and auditable form.

Electricity consumption and grid emissions

Furna Metali's metered electricity consumption exists in EPCG's billing systems. Montenegro's Regulatory Energy Agency (RAE) holds the national grid's emissions-intensity data. Neither system is designed to deliver this to a small metal fabrication company in the format required by ESRS or CSRD Scope 2 accounting fields.

Waste data

Furna Metali's hazardous and non-hazardous waste streams are reported to Montenegro's EPA by its licensed waste operator, in accordance with that operator's permit obligations. The data exists — reported by the waste hauler to the authorities — but it is held in the EPA's environmental permitting system and is not accessible to Furna Metali in structured, attributable form.

Physical climate risk

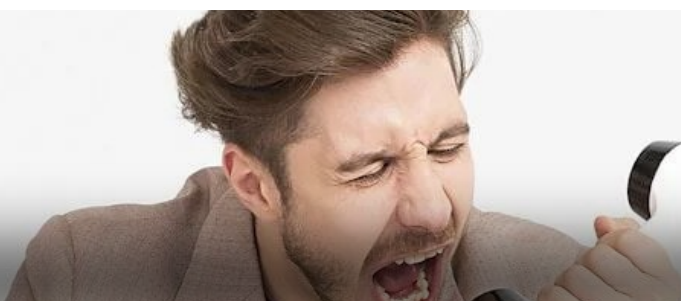
Montenegro's Institute of Hydrometeorology and Seismology maintains national datasets for flood risk, groundwater, and temperature projections. These are referenced in Montenegro's Chapter 27 environmental acquis and underpin the country's Natura 2000 assessments. They are publicly available but not in formats that can be integrated directly into a supplier questionnaire or a bank's climate risk disclosure template.

Company identity and classification data

The Central Registry of Commercial Entities (CRPS) holds Furna Metali's registration number, sector classification (NACE code), employee headcount, and turnover band — the building blocks of any regulatory framework's entity-level scoping determination. This data already exists and is well-structured, but there is no mechanism for an SME to authorize a third party to pull it on demand to populate a sustainability disclosure.

ETS and environmental permit data

The EPA's ETS registry holds emissions allowance data and industrial permit classifications. A structured query against this data could resolve Furna Metali's uncertainty about whether it falls within the national ETS scope. Instead, Dragon is manually interpreting legal annexes.



Where Dragan's Answers Actually Live

Data Need	Regulatory Framework	Source Registry	Current Accessibility
Electricity consumption (kWh)	Scope 2 (CSRD / VSME)	EPCG billing system	Inaccessible to SME in structured form
Grid emissions factor (gCO _{2e} /kWh)	Scope 2 market-based	RAE national grid data	Published; outdated; not API-formatted
Hazardous waste volumes by stream	Waste reporting (CSRD / CSDDD)	EPA environmental permits / waste operator	Held by operator; not SME-facing
Flood risk classification (10-yr)	Physical risk (EBA guidelines, green loans)	Institute of Hydrometeorology	Publicly available; not structured for disclosure
Climate projections (temperature)	Transition risk assessment	EPA / Hydromet Institute	Published; not structured for SME disclosure
Company entity data (employees, sector, turnover)	CSRD entity-level scoping	CRPS (Central Registry)	Accessible; no SME consent-and-share mechanism
ETS scope classification	Climate Law 2025 / national ETS	EPA ETS registry	Exists; requires legal interpretation to access
Chemical discharge / EPA permit history	CSDDD due diligence	EPA environmental permitting system	Exists; not accessible to permit-holder's SME

The Montenegrin SME Data Environment: Unique Complexities

The accession premium

Montenegrin SMEs face a double compliance burden that their Norwegian counterparts do not. In Norway, the regulatory framework is settled — the question is how to extract data from existing, well-functioning registries. In Montenegro, the framework itself is still being built. The Law on Accounting 2025, the revised Climate Law, the ETS alignment with EU MRV rules — these are all recent developments, and the administrative interpretation of their requirements is still evolving. Furna Metali is being asked to report against frameworks that its own national regulators are still implementing.

The CBAM transition exposure

Furna Metali does not export directly to the EU — but its steel components are embedded in products and structures that do. The CBAM's definitive phase, which began in January 2026, creates an indirect competitiveness risk: if the embedded carbon in Furna Metali's steel cannot be documented and verified, its EU-headquartered clients face higher CBAM liabilities, which they will pass down the supply chain through pricing pressure or supplier substitution. The risk of supply chain exclusion is not hypothetical. It is already visible in the Italian logistics company's supplier data requests.

The grid emissions trap

Montenegro's electricity system creates a specific and acute reporting problem. The Pljevlja coal-fired thermal power plant is the sole remaining large industrial installation in the national ETS. The grid emissions factor for Montenegro is, in default CBAM methodology, calculated as a fossil-fuel-weighted average — which significantly overstates the actual carbon intensity of electricity consumed by businesses like Furna Metali that receive supply partly derived from hydropower. Without a structured, verifiable mechanism to access market-based emissions data or guarantee-of-origin certificates, Montenegrin SMEs are locked into using a default factor that damages their reported emissions profile and their competitiveness.

Capacity constraints with no equivalent to Magnet JQS

Norway's offshore supply chain has a partial precedent for shared data infrastructure: the Magnet JQS qualification system, which collects and maintains standardised company profile data on behalf of operators. Montenegro has no equivalent. There is no sector-level shared data repository, no industry-coordinated qualification system, and no professional body with the mandate or resources to build one. The gap is entirely unmediated

The problem is not that Montenegro lacks data. It is that the data lives in separate agencies, each governed by different statutory mandates, none designed to interoperate with each other or to serve an SME's reporting needs.

What SME Data Unlock Could Do for Furna Metali

SME Data Unlock proposes a consent-based data highway that allows Furna Metali DOO to authorize — through a single interaction built on Montenegro's existing eGovernment identity infrastructure — the retrieval of its data from the registries where it already resides. A structured data pull for Furna Metali's annual sustainability disclosure would draw from the following sources:

Data Need	Regulatory Framework	Source Registry	What Changes
Electricity consumption (kWh by period)	Scope 2 CSRD/VSME	EPCG / RAE	Automated pull, mapped to ESRS fields
Grid emissions factor (current year)	Scope 2 market-based	RAE	Machine-readable, annually updated
Waste volumes by stream and classification	CSRD / CSDDD waste reporting	EPA permits / waste operator registry	SME-facing structured output on consent
Flood & climate risk (facility-level)	EBA ESG / green loan criteria	Hydromet Institute / EPA	API-formatted risk score for disclosure
Company entity data (scoping)	CSRD entity-level scoping	CRPS Central Registry	Consent-based third-party data share
ETS scope classification	Climate Law 2025	EPA ETS registry	Structured determination, not legal guesswork
Chemical discharge & permit history	CSDDD due diligence	EPA environmental permits	Attributed, time-stamped, machine-readable

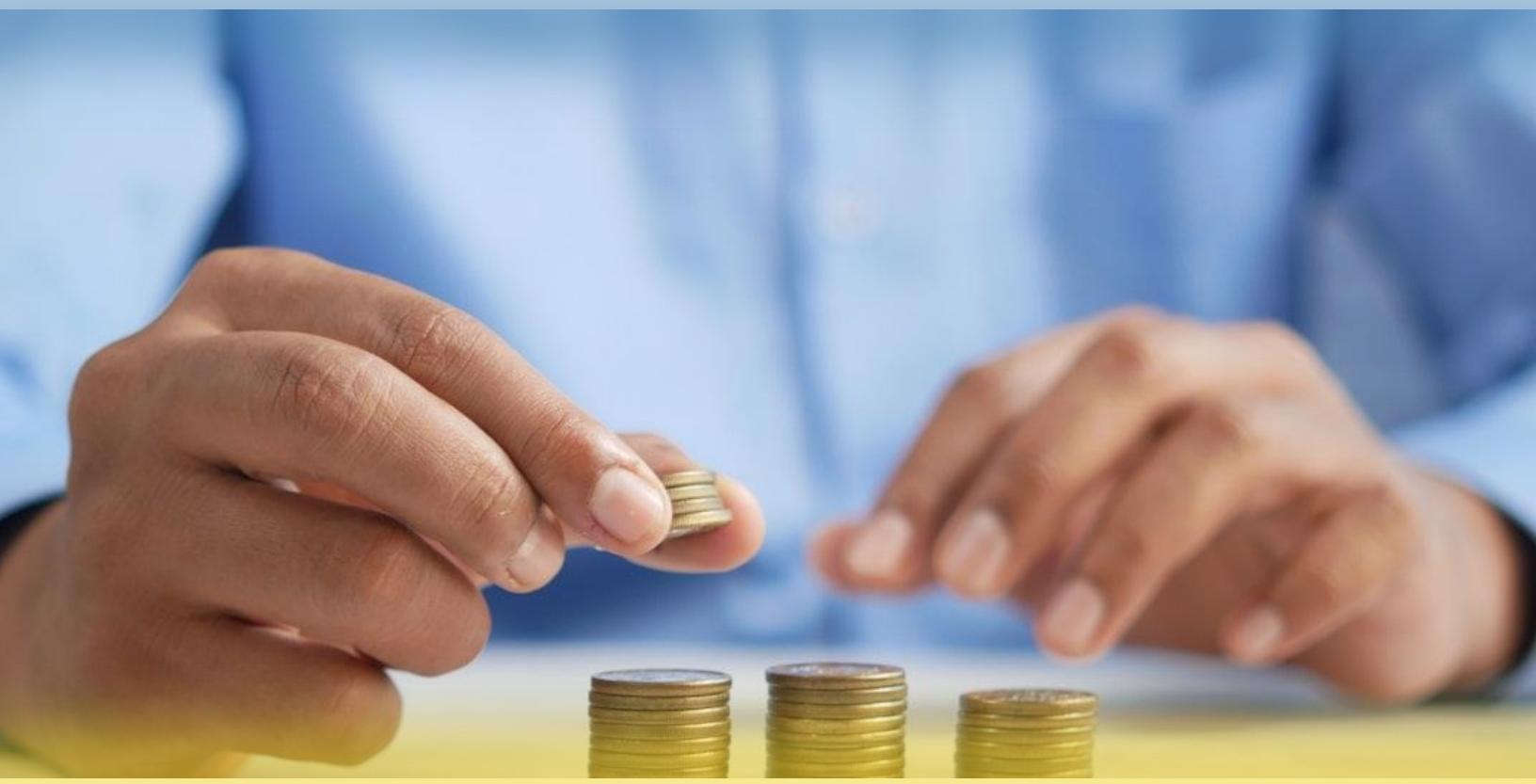
The goal is a single, SME-controlled consent flow that authorizes data retrieval from these sources, maps the outputs to the relevant reporting fields — VSME, ESRS, EFRAG taxonomy, or a specific client questionnaire schema — and produces a structured, machine-readable disclosure that can be submitted to any requesting party: the Italian logistics buyer, the Austrian energy company, the bank, the EPA. Without replication of manual effort.

Illustrative Savings: Furna Metali DOO

The figures below are illustrative models, not measured results. They apply conservative assumptions to Furna Metali's profile: a 28-person company receiving four structured sustainability data requests per year.

Scenario	Without SME Data Unlock	With SME Data Unlock	Annual Saving
In-house (HSE supervisor)	~EUR 6,200 / yr (est. 12 days @ EUR 500/day)	~EUR 1,200 / yr (est. 2.5 days)	EUR ~5,000/yr
Outsourced (ESG consultant)	EUR 14,000-18,000 / yr	EUR 2,500-4,000 / yr	EUR ~11,000-14,000/yr

Not shown: EUR 180,000 green loan access — currently blocked because the emissions baseline documentation required for NLB's green facility cannot be produced in an auditable form. The preferential rate represents approximately EUR 12,000 in savings over the loan term.



Why the Data Gap Is Harder to Close in Montenegro — and Why It Must Be Closed

Montenegro's regulatory bodies are functioning — the EPA, the Central Registry, the Institute of Hydrometeorology, the Regulatory Energy Agency — but each holds data under its own mandate, structured for its own purposes, governed by its own access rules. No body has the cross-cutting mandate to build a consent-driven interoperability layer for SME sustainability disclosures.

The Montenegro Ministry of Finance owns the Accounting Act and the sustainability reporting rules — not the data highway beneath them. The Ministry of Ecology owns climate targets — not digital infrastructure. The Ministry of Public Administration owns e-government infrastructure — but does not set sustainability reporting requirements. The EPA runs environmental registers — but is not responsible for SME competitiveness. The CRPS runs business registers — but does not operate a data exchange for sustainability disclosures.

Each body is doing its job. The problem lives in the gaps between them. And problems that live in the gaps between mandates are, by definition, no one's problem — until someone with cross-cutting authority decides to own them.

That is precisely what SME Data Unlock Alliance is asking Montenegro to do. Not to build the platform itself, but to make three foundational decisions that only government can make:

- **Establish the legal basis for cross-registry consent** — create the mechanism that allows a business to grant time-limited, purpose-limited access to its data across multiple registries simultaneously, using existing eGovernment identity infrastructure.
- **Mandate interoperability standards** — standardize the output format across the EPA, RAE, CRPS, and Hydromet Institute so that data speaks a common machine-readable language that maps to ESRS, VSME, and EFRAG taxonomy fields. No individual registry has an incentive to do this on its own.
- **Designate an owner** — a body with the mandate, the resources, and the cross-agency authority to build and maintain the connective layer. In the Norwegian context, this is framed around Altinn and Digitaliseringsdirektoratet. In Montenegro, it could be the e-Government Authority (eUprava), the Ministry of Public Administration, or a dedicated function anchored in the EU accession structure itself



The EU Accession Argument

Montenegro has a structural advantage that makes this argument particularly compelling: EU accession gives the government both the mandate and the political deadline. The Chapter 27 closing benchmarks require verified environmental data, functioning MRV systems, and credible corporate sustainability disclosures. These are not soft objectives — they are measurable conditions for accession.

Building the SME data infrastructure that enables Furna Metali to produce auditable sustainability disclosures is not separate from the accession agenda. It is part of it. An SME sector that can demonstrate verified ESG performance to EU buyers, banks, and regulators is an SME sector that contributes to Chapter 27 compliance — and to Montenegro's competitiveness in European supply chains after accession.

The UNDP/ILO Circular Transition project currently running through March 2027 offers a partial precedent: digital self-assessment tools and ESG capacity building for Montenegrin MSMEs. What it lacks — what no program of self-assessment tools can supply — is the connective infrastructure that would make those assessments verifiable, attributable, and reusable across every reporting context a Montenegrin SME faces.

The data gap is a competitiveness gap. And in Montenegro's case, it is also an accession gap.



The Cost of Inaction

The cost of not solving this is not abstract. It is measured in green loans that Montenegrin SMEs do not apply for; in framework agreements they lose because they cannot complete CSDDD due diligence requests; in CBAM liabilities that their EU clients pass down the supply chain as pricing pressure; and in capital investment in cleaner operations that does not happen because the emissions baseline data required to access it cannot be produced.

Montenegro's industrial SME sector — metal fabricators, food processors, energy sub-contractors, agricultural suppliers — is precisely the sector that EU buyers are scrutinizing most intensively as CSRD and CSDDD compliance tightens. It is also the sector least equipped to respond. And it is the sector for which the data most needed for compliance already exists in national public systems — held by agencies that have no mechanism to deliver it.

The question is not whether Montenegro has the data. It does. The question is not whether the technology to connect it exists. It does. The question is whether anyone owns the problem. Currently, no one does. Ultimately, it is Dragan — Furna Metali's HSE supervisor, working from a spreadsheet — who owns the data gap.

Call to Action

SME Data Unlock Alliance proposes to build the connective layer: an open-source, AI-powered taxonomy-mapping platform combined with a consent-driven data-sharing trust framework, anchored in Montenegro's existing e-government infrastructure and jointly governed by the agencies that hold the source data.

For Montenegrin industrial SMEs, this is not only a question of reporting efficiency. It is a supply chain survival question. SME suppliers that cannot produce auditable sustainability data will lose access to green financing, lose supply chain positions with EU operators tightening their CSRD and CSDDD compliance, and be unable to contribute to Montenegro's own Chapter 27 accession commitments.



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